

Congressional Debate Basics

What is the event

TLDR you pretend you're congresspeople and you're passing and proposing laws and debating "bills" or "resolutions" that try and change current laws

Congressional debate (congress for short) is a combination of both speech and debate

You need good speech skills since you're supposed to present yourself as a congressperson

You need good debate skills since it is congressional "debate" and you need to address the arguments other people give

What you do during the debate

One of the people in round is a PO (presiding officer), also referred to as the chair. This person picks the people to go up and give speeches in affirmative and negative cycles.

For example, the presiding officer may say: “this congress is now in session. All speakers wishing to speak in the affirmative please rise.”

If you're not the presiding officer, you're a speaker and you wait to be called on which side you want to speak on (affirmation/negation)

Speeches

3 minute speech, followed by 1 minute of cross-examination

However, if you are the first speech of your side (first aff or neg speaker), there are 2 minutes of cross-examination

Cross-examination

Other people in the round ask you question(s) about your speech

Indirect: they ask one question, can be as many questions in a 1 or 2-minute period

Direct: they can ask as many questions and it's sort of free-flowing for 30 second blocks

DO NOT bring up any evidence in a question unless it has already been brought up or it is common knowledge, that's a "leading question" and is not allowed

Recency

Speeches	O	I	II	III							
1.	Lung	Misra A	Misra A			Start Time:	2:25 PM PST				2/3= 11
2.	Chordiya	Lung N	Lung N			End Time:	5:05 PM PST				1/2= 8
3.	Jain	Chordiya A	Singh A								
4.	Sripada	Bhattacharya N	Jain N			Bill	Pass	Fail	Abstain		Speeches:
5.	Bhattacharya	Jain A	Kukreja A			Gas Tax	9	6	0		Questions:
6.	Kukreja	Prasad N	Piplani N			Crypto	7	6	0		
7.	Gupta	Kukreja A	Gupta A								
8.	Piplani	Petrov N	Prasad N								
9.	Petrov	Saxena A	Bhattacharya N			PO Shreya Sripada					
10.	Ponnaluri	Piplani N	Chordiya A								
11.	Prasad	Sripada A	Saxena N								
12.	Saxena	Ponnaluri N	Petrov A								
13.	Ravi	Singh A	Ponnaluri N								
14.	Singh	Gupta A	Ravi A								
15.	Misra	Ravi A									
16.	Hudda	Hudda A									
Questions	O	I	II	III	IV	V	VI	VII	VIII	IX	X
1.	Lung	Lung	Lung	Lung	Lung	Lung	Lung				
2.	Chordiya	Ponnaluri	Ponnaluri	Prasad	Jain	Jain					
3.	Jain	Prasad	Prasad	Ponnaluri	Prasad	Prasad					
4.	Sripada	Piplani	Saxena	Saxena	Ponnaluri	Ponnaluri					
5.	Bhattacharya	Saxena	Piplani	Jain	Petrov	Petrov					
6.	Kukreja	Chordiya	Chordiya	Petrov	Kukreja	Saxena					
7.	Gupta	Ravi	Jain	Kukreja	Piplani	Bhattacharya					
8.	Piplani	Singh	Petrov	Piplani	Saxena						
9.	Petrov	Jain	Singh	Misra	Misra						
10.	Ponnaluri	Kukreja	Kukreja	Gupta	Gupta						
11.	Prasad	Bhattacharya	Bhattacharya	Bhattacharya	Bhattacharya						
12.	Saxena	Petrov	Sripada	Chordiya	Hudda						
13.	Ravi	Misra	Misra	Hudda							
14.	Singh	Gupta	Gupta								
15.	Misra	Sripada	Hudda								
16.	Hudda	Hudda									

Basically shows who gets to speak first in round, the earlier you speak, the better for later rounds since you get to pick when you speak

Motions

Motions are just a fancy way of saying you want to get things done, here are the important ones:

PO motions for docket nominations, pick the topic of the round “I now open the floor for docket nominations” ends with “are there any more docket nominations?”

“Motion to open congress” - start the round

“Motion to previous question” - end the round and vote to pass/fail the legislation

“Motion of personal privilege” - I need to piss or leave the room for some other reason

“Point of order” - PO did something wrong

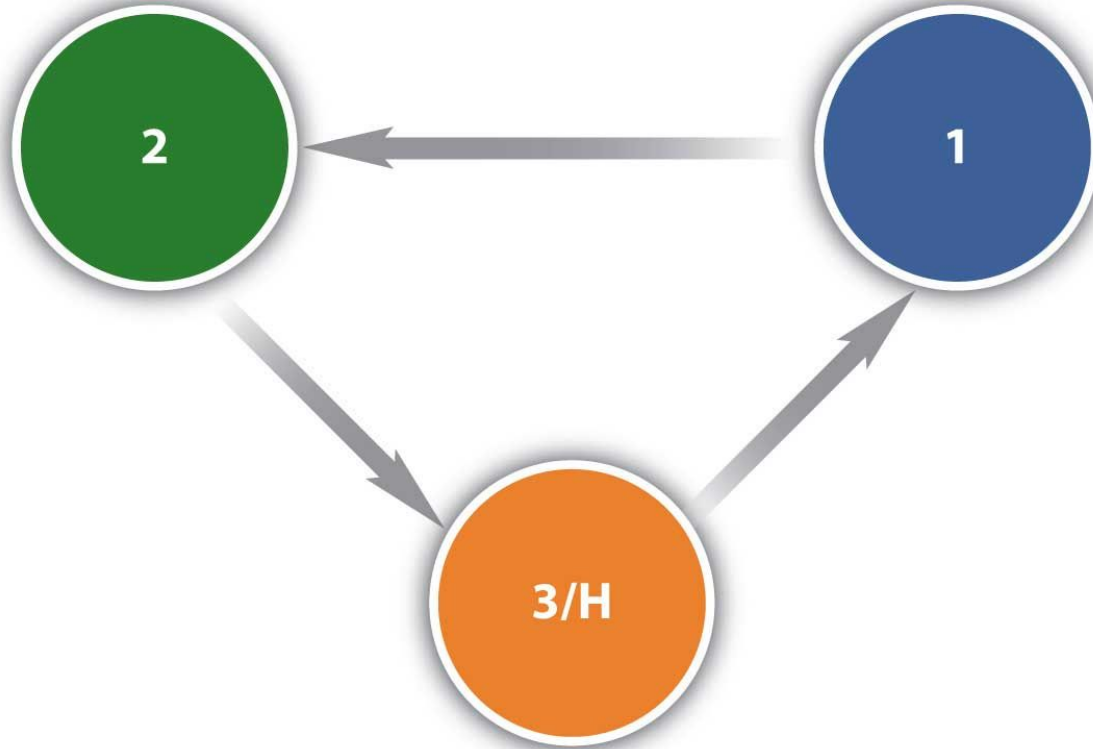
“Out of order” - PO tells someone to stop goofing

<https://www.speechanddebate.org/wp-content/uploads/Congressional-Debate-Frequently-Used-Motions.pdf>

How to deliver congress speeches in general

- Act as if you are an actual congressperson and have the demeanor, persona, charisma, decorum, etc.
- Since a lot of congress is about your delivery and round presence, make sure to use the room and walk around in the speech triangle (on next slide)
- Make eye contact with the chamber and your judges to be memorable
- Use hand gestures **MEANINGFULLY**

This is where/how you should be walking in round (e.g. for each point in your speech)



Delivery styles

This guy was really good and has a style that is almost like the dominant strategy rn (circa 2022), but opt for unique delivery style and don't be a drone



Different types of speeches

Sponsorship/Authorship speech:

- This speech proves why we need to pass the bill as well as introducing the problem the bill is aiming to solve
- Should show problem and solution as well as 2 points

Mid-round speech:

- Any speech before the authorship speech but before the last speech
- Should have “clash” - basically referencing other speakers and adding onto or refuting their points

Different types of speeches (cont.)

Crystallization speech:

- Usually harder to pull off
- You should be summarizing the round and the arguments made that round
- “Every line should be a bone-chilling refutation,” you shouldn’t be bringing up a lot of new evidence but instead focusing on the round and why one side won over the other, a lot of impact weighing
- Pick the main points of the debate that have been brought up, e.g. if multiple speakers have referenced this point it was important in the debate, then weigh the impacts from both sides to show who won the debate and why you pass/fail

Speech structure (author/sponsor)

1. Intro
 - a. Keep it around 50 ish words
2. What's the problem + how this bill solves for it
 - a. Make sure you still include CEW in this part of the speech
 - b. Should be around half of your speech
3. What happens when you pass this bill?
 - a. Claim
 - b. Evidence
 - c. Warrant/Analysis
4. Conclusion

Speech structure (mid-round)

1. Intro

- a. Keep it around 50 words

2. Point (2 at the very least)

- a. Claim
- b. Evidence
- c. Warrant/Analysis
- d. Each point should be around 150 words

3. Conclusion

- a. A quick sentence with a bit of rhetoric, link back to your intro for brownie points

Speech structure (crystal)

1. Intro

- a. Make sure you have a memorable intro, being the last in the round is already hard, almost everything in this speech needs to make you stand out

2. Important points in debate (should have like 3)

- a. Aff speaker said this vs neg speaker said this, **introduce the claim**
- b. Bring up evidence from both sides
- c. Analyze the evidence
- d. Why is one side's evidence better and why do they have a bigger impact?

3. Conclusion

- a. Make your conclusion even more dramatic than usual, link back to your intro

Argument structure

Basically like a CER

Claim - this bill puts technological access into those who are disadvantaged

Evidence - this bill funds \$500 million for school districts. According to ... the main reason schools don't have widespread tech is bc they are underfunded etc.

Warrant - this means ...

Impact -

You usually want two stats to support your point and your impact.

Writing intros

This is a good way to separate yourself in the round early on before judges zone out. Some intros can be very dramatic/rhetorical while others are humorous. Keep it around 50 words and keep eye contact with your audience while delivering this.

Intros will vary depending on whether you're on aff/neg

Ex:

1. (AFF) Since the beginning of the Industrial Revolution, society has never quite been able to balance ethics with economics. 300 years later, and the problem is worse than ever. We're so distracted by the glossy exterior of our computers, phones, and watches that we don't consider the blood, sweat, and tears that go into producing them. It's time we shed a light.
2. (NEG) Every tool has its purpose: if you're going to be judging a hammer by its ability to cut up paper, of course it's going to be inefficient. The affirmation needs to understand that the filibuster is not a tool designed for speed, but rather, accuracy. Sen. Wampler could not answer this when I asked in cross-examination, so let's truly understand what the point of a filibuster is today:

Writing conclusions

Link back to your intro if you want, not completely necessary

You can also be cheap and just say “it is for these reasons that I stand on the aff/neg.” End with “affirm/fail” as just one word so your PO knows when your speech is done and you remind the judge which side you’re on.

Ex:

If there’s anything that should guide your ballot today, it’s the voice of morality and the needs of the marginalized. Affirm.

Debate slang/vocab

“Lay” - a casual style of anything debate related, whether that’s a judge, speaking style, or a way a tournament is organized in general

“Flow” - a way of taking notes in round and keeping track of arguments, can also refer to a judge (flow judge vs lay judge)

Ex: Lay judges usually don’t flow the round

“Solvency” - how effective is your solution vs the problem, very important concept and term in congress